1046 BC) have now been confirmed by modern archaeology. Inscriptions on oracle bones and bronze artifacts confirm much of what is mentioned in the ancient texts. Of course, there are gaps between thearchaeological findings and the information in the texts [5] , but this is only to be expected after such a long lapse of time.

As mentioned earlier, the Mahabharata largely has an East–West orientation unlike the North–South orientation of the Ramayana. Most of the action takes place around Delhi and the Gangetic plains but the eastern and western extremes of the subcontinent also play an important role in the unfolding events. The Kauravs' mother Gandhari is from the kingdom of Gandhar which is now eastern Afghanistan. Her devious brother Shakuni instigates his nephews against the Pandavs, fixes the game of dice and ultimately causes the war.

On the other geographical extreme, India's North East finds mention for the first time. Arjuna, the most dashing of the Pandav brothers, makes his way to remote Manipur during his years of exile. There he meets the warrior-princess Chitrangada. They fall in love and marry, albeit on the condition that Chitrangada would not have to follow Arjuna back to the Gangetic plains. Their son eventually becomes the king of Manipur and would participate in the Kurukshetra battle.

The people of the tiny Bishnupriya community that still lives in Manipur and neighbouring states trace their origins to the Mahabharata. They speak a language that is related to Assamese and has many Tibeto–Burman words, but still preserves several features of archaic Prakrit. Does the Chitrangada legend preserve the memory of an ancient migration into this area? The Bishnupriyas were a powerful clan in Manipur till the nineteenth century when a Burmese invasion scattered them. They now live in a few villages in Assam and Manipur, and there is a danger that their language and unique culture will get lost within a generation or two. [6]

Since the Kurukshetra battle is said to have involved all the tribes and kingdoms of India, the Mahabharata gives us long lists of kingdoms, clans and cities. Many of them were probably added to the text in later times.